

S A R A ' S B L O G

The story behind the **WORLD CHAMPION**



When the results were announced, it felt like time froze!

For the first time in Moroccan history and for the first time in Africa our team won the 2nd Prize in cake design. A victory for both men and women in the pastry field. A moment carved in gold. A page added to our culinary history.

i am Chef Sara Alaoui, Cake designer and this is my story .

This year, I had the honor of representing Morocco at one of the biggest pastry competitions in the world

It was my first time. No warm-up. No test round. Just a dream, a team, and a mountain of determination. The days in Rome were a whirlwind of precision and adrenaline. Every hour was a negotiation with time, temperature, and technique. Every minute was a reminder of why pastry is part science, part art.

S A R A ' S B L O G



“Then this call arrived, as if someone somewhere said, “Alright, get up. It’s time”

There’s a part of this story that I never shared before.

Before Rome, before the stage lights and the rush of competition, I was paused. Completely paused. I had stepped away from work, convinced I needed a long break. Maybe too long. There were days when I thought I might never return. That chapter is a whole story for another time to share, but it shaped everything that came next.

The strange thing about life is how it whispers before it shouts. My return didn’t start with a plan, or a strategy, or a sign from the sky. It started with a phone call.

A man I barely had any connection with someone with whom I had a small business interaction back in 2012 (Mr Amine: CEO of MasterGel) had been quietly following my work ever since. He believed in me without ever telling me. And when he finally had an opportunity, he picked up the phone and called...

“Are you interested in representing Morocco in Cake Design in Rome?”

For a second, I didn’t even breathe. Was this real?

Because the truth is, just a few days before that call, I had told my husband how much I wished for a big chance. Something that would push me, break the routine, and bring me back to myself. I wished for a competition that would challenge my limits. It felt like an impossible dream.

Then this call arrived, as if someone somewhere said, “Alright, get up. It’s time.”

That was the moment my comeback began not loud, not dramatic just a spark. A door opening. A reminder that sometimes life waits for you to be honest about what you want before it answers.

And from that phone call, destiny took over.

“Who do you want as your second for the competition?”

I didn’t even blink. The answer came out of me faster than my own heartbeat.

*“Of course, **Sara El Fetouh.**”*

For ten years, she has been my right hand, my mirror, my partner in the chaos and beauty of this craft. We’ve shared long nights, quiet victories, failures that felt like earthquakes, and those rare moments when everything finally works. She’s the one who walked every step of this journey with me. There was never a moment of hesitation. If I was going to carry Morocco to Rome, she was the one who deserved to stand beside me.

It felt like the universe saying: *now it’s her time to shine too.*

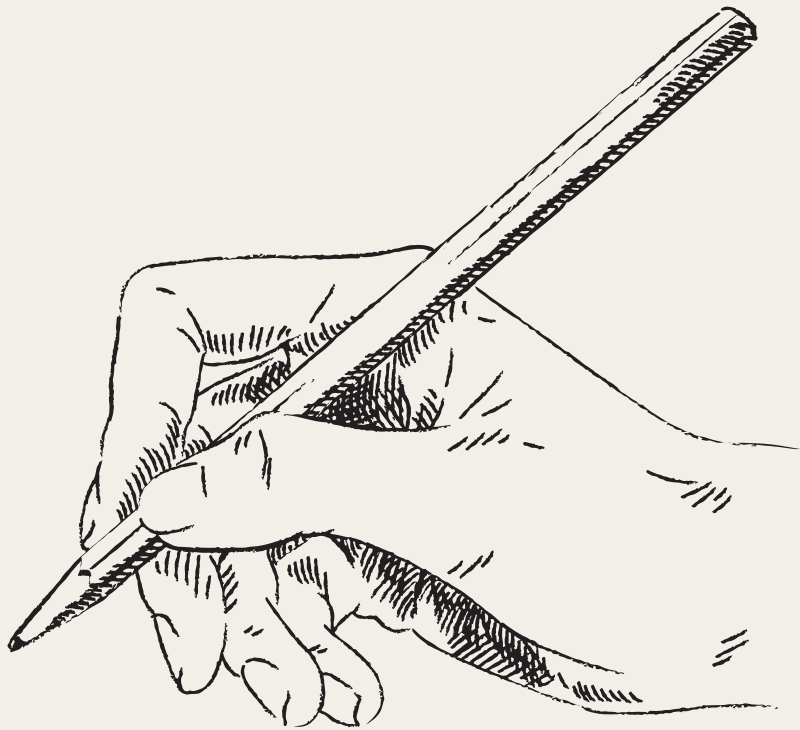
S A R A ' S B L O G

One cake, one structure, one journey across the country's spine

After choosing my second, he sent me everything: the full dossier of the World Championship in Rome 2025, the FIPGC rules, the timings, the requirements... and then the theme.

“Representing the Beauty of Your Nature.”

The moment I read it, something inside me lit up. I felt even happier not just because the theme was beautiful, but because it was ours. Moroccan nature. Our colors, our landscapes, our soul. And with that happiness came a wave of responsibility. This wasn't just a cake anymore. This was a portrait of a country.



I sat down with my sketchbook like someone meeting an old friend. Lines turned into shapes, shapes turned into ideas, and ideas became questions. How do I honor a country that stretches from the deep silence of the Sahara to the green breath of the North? How do I compress mountains, dunes, coasts, cities, and culture into one sculpture that stands tall and speaks clearly?

Then a brilliant idea arrived, sharp and bold.

Represent Morocco from Sahara to North.

One cake, one structure, one journey across the country's spine.

It felt impossible. It felt exciting. It felt like exactly the challenge I needed after coming back from that long pause. The more I thought about it, the more alive the piece became in my mind textures of sand, colors of sea, architecture, movement, tradition, light... all layered into one edible creation.

That's when the real adventure began.

S A R A ' S B L O G

The biggest challenge wasn't the structure !

It wasn't the symbolism. It wasn't even the technical requirements of the World Championship.

The real shock was the timing.

We received the call only two months before the competition. Two months for a world-level project that usually takes almost a year. And as if that wasn't wild enough, I had barely one week just one to create the entire sketch. That week felt like living inside a dream and a storm at the same time. I thought about the design day and night. I woke up in the middle of the night with ideas burning in my mind, afraid they would disappear by morning. Sometimes I even dreamed the structure, and I would jump out of bed to draw it before it evaporated like smoke. Every hour counted. Every minute felt borrowed.

After seven days of nonstop work, confusion, excitement, and pure creative madness... we finally reached this design the one you see here. The one that felt right in the heart and in the mind.



Page from the Brochure

A vertical walk through Morocco, from the deep breath of the Sahara to the proud mountains of central Morocco, all the way to the fertile orchards of the North. A structure that climbs like the country itself. Seeing it all come together felt like breathing again after holding my breath for too long. This was the moment we knew: we found it. The design that would carry our country to Rome.

S A R A ' S B L O G

Because Morocco has everything !

Then came the palette choice probably the second biggest challenge for me, although sometimes it feels like the first. Colors are emotional. They decide the whole personality of a piece. And this time, choosing a palette felt almost impossible. Why?

Because Morocco has everything.

We’re one of those rare countries that truly lives all four seasons. The warm golden breath of the Sahara. The deep blues of the North. The earthy reds of traditional architecture. The bright greens of our valleys. The tangerine sunsets that look painted by someone with too much imagination.

How do you choose just a few colors when your country is a full spectrum?

Every shade carried meaning. Every tone felt like a piece of home. That’s why the palette wasn’t just decoration. It was identity. It had to be subtle but powerful, modern but authentic, artistic but recognizably Moroccan. Finding harmony between all those landscapes that was its own little battle. And somehow, through that chaos of options, *the palette finally appeared like a whisper that made perfect sense.*



Page from the Brochure

The deep blues of the North, the warm golds of the South, the greens of our valleys, the tangerine glow that follows us everywhere. Once all these colors stood together, they formed exactly what I needed: *a palette that breathed Morocco in every shade.*

S A R A ’ S B L O G

Beneath the tangerines Sun ...

Now it was time to choose the cake flavor. Normally, this part never stresses me. Creating new recipes from zero is something I’m used to, and I rarely feel unsafe about it. But this competition wasn’t like every other project. I felt a real pressure to find something truly different something that fit the theme perfectly.

I knew I needed a flavor that connected to the story, so I went straight to tangerines and oranges. They matched the theme, they represented Morocco, and they brought freshness and brightness to the concept.

But flavor wasn’t enough. I wanted a Moroccan twist that added texture and identity. That’s why I chose filo rolls thin, crispy layers that bring contrast and a unique bite inside the cake. I also wanted the inside cut of the cake to look beautiful and clean. In competitions, the slice matters as much as the whole cake. Everything has to work together: **flavor, cut, structure, and theme.**

Here is the slice I created



Page from the Brochure

Each layer had a purpose. The dark chocolate and fleur d’oranger ganache brought depth and a strong aromatic base. The milk-chocolate cake with orange zest added softness and balance. The insert was a concentrated mix of tangerine and citrus fruits to bring brightness. The filo rolls created a thin, crispy contrast in the middle something different that still made sense with the Moroccan identity.

The whole cake was coated with a 72% chocolate ganache to keep the outside stable, and the white-chocolate ganache with tangerine purée tied the theme together. Everything needed to align: the story, the flavor, the look of the slice, the technique, and the final structure. This composition became the foundation of “*Beneath the Tangerine Sun.*”

S A R A ' S B L O G



That was the first thing we started working on: the actual cake flavor. We tested three different chocolate cake recipes, checking the texture, the moisture level, and whether the cake needed a syrup or not. At first we went with a syrup, but then we changed the plan and returned to what we're known for: a naturally moist cake that doesn't need any soaking. It's part of our signature.

This phase took time, but it built the foundation of everything that came after.

We also tested the filo rolls. We experimented with different diameters, different sheet lengths, and how tight the roll should be to stay fluffy inside but still crispy after baking. That part felt like real alchemy. Every day was a new test: too soft, too hard, too thick, too thin... until we finally found the perfect balance.



The tangerine insert also took time to get right. We wanted the natural taste to stay exactly as it is: not too sweet, not too sour, and definitely not artificial. Tangerines can change from one batch to another, so every test felt like adjusting a tiny equation. We tried different cooking times, different purée concentrations, and even different ways of stabilizing the insert without losing that fresh citrus punch. It was a small detail, but in competitions, small details decide everything.

Ten days passed before we all agreed on the final version. We even studied Rome's temperature, because we're used to Moroccan weather and we needed to predict how the cake would behave there. Then came the cutting tests: once, twice, again checking stability, clean slicing, and how the layers held together.

S A R A ’ S B L O G



And yes, this is the final slice we ended up with. Beautiful, delicious, and exactly what we wanted. But the real challenge wasn’t creating it in the lab. The big question was:

can we reproduce all of this in just two hours, under pressure, in front of judges, cameras, and the whole world watching?

We had to face it: we complicated the procedure. Too many recipes, too many steps, too many small details that felt “essential” at the moment. We were so focused on creating the perfect flavor and structure that we completely forgot about the timing we actually had in the competition. Two hours is nothing when you’re working with multiple ganaches, inserts, filo rolls, precise layering, and a cake that must look flawless from the inside and the outside. It was a bit funny and a bit scary at the same time, we had built a masterpiece... *but could we actually pull it off live?*



S A R A ' S B L O G

THE RULES



Before going further, you need to understand the rules of the **FIPGC** competition in Italy, because this is where the real stress begins. We weren't going to make just one cake we had to produce three live. Two cakes for the judges to taste and evaluate, and a third one that would be inserted inside the big showpiece. The showpiece itself had to demonstrate our decoration skills, so it was built on a dummy base with one real cake hidden inside.

The two tasting cakes were 15 cm in diameter, and the one inside the showpiece had to be at least 20 cm. The base of the whole showpiece couldn't exceed 80 cm. The height was free, but every decoration had to be edible. We were allowed to bring pre-made elements, but only if we finished them on site. And of course, the cakes themselves had to be baked from scratch during the competition. Only prebaked sponges, no shortcuts just raw ingredients and technique.

And everything had to arrive separated: tools, molds, dummies, decorations, ingredients... nothing assembled.

In total, we had four hours. Two hours dedicated to baking and finishing the cakes, and two hours to decorate the big showpiece. When you put all these rules together, you can imagine the pressure we felt. It was not just about creating a beautiful cake it was about timing, coordination, precision, and surviving under a clock that doesn't forgive anyone.

But even after hearing all these rules... we still believed in ourselves. Nothing really scares us anymore. This job trained us to handle stress in ways people can't even imagine. We've been through situations where the pressure was much higher than any competition clock.

I still remember that big event where the normal preparation needed two full days of work and we had only four hours on site to finish everything. And we did it. We didn't panic, we didn't freeze. We just looked at each other and said the same sentence we always say:

“Naaaaa, we can do it, it's nothing.”

And somehow... it always works.

That mindset followed us to Rome. The rules were heavy, the timing was crazy, but deep inside we kept that same energy: *trust the process, trust the experience, and trust the team.*

S A R A ’ S B L O G

They also asked every team to send a **brochure** where we explain our design, our techniques, introduce the team, share the idea, the recipes basically everything behind the creation. So I started writing it while I was working on the decorations. To be honest, I actually enjoyed making the brochure. I love designing on Canva, and it felt like a nice break from the usual routine. Morning was all about decorations, and night was all about writing and designing the brochure. I even helped the chocolate team and wrote their brochure too. It felt refreshing, like I was changing my work rhythm for a while.

You’ll find the PDF at the end of the blog.

That part was also creative, and honestly I want you to look at it because it came straight from my heart. The title of the project arrived in my mind without any effort: **UNDER THE TANGERINES SUN.**

Why this name? Because tangerines, as everyone knows, come from Tangier the city where I was born.

UNDER

the tangerine sun

Tangerines themselves have a story. The name “tangerine” actually comes from Tangier, because the fruit was first exported to Europe from the port of Tangier in the 19th century. Anything that arrived from Tangier was called “tangerine.” With time, the word became the official name of the fruit. So in a way, tangerines carry the identity of my city in their name.

And I chose “under the sun” because Morocco starts from the very top, my Tangier, and goes all the way down to the Sahara. The whole country sits under one long line of sun, colors, and landscapes. The title felt right immediately. It connected the theme, the flavor, the culture, and my personal story in one sentence.

S A R A ' S B L O G

NEXT CHAPTER

During the decoration phase, we worked on the figurines, the trees, and the leaves more than 2000 leaves, by the way. Surprisingly, this part wasn't the difficult one. Chef Sara El Fetouh handled the trees perfectly, and I focused on the figurines and the whole structure. The architectural side was actually the easiest for us. We're used to building complex pieces, so that challenge went smoothly. one big tangerines tree on the top with more than 2000 leafs , and 6 palm trees in the sahara (the base).



There was another challenge we gave ourselves

something no one asked for, but we wanted to push our limits even more. We decided to use zero molds and zero silicone tools. Everything had to be made 100% by hand. No shortcuts, no premade shapes, no support pieces. Just pure craftsmanship.



For the figurines, we created characters that represented Morocco from North to South. A Jebliya woman with her traditional clothing, holding her cat, symbolizing the North and the mountains of Tangier and Chefchaouen. A lion standing for the Middle Atlas, powerful and proud. A Sahraoui man representing the Sahara, carrying the identity and culture of the South. And at the base of the showpiece, camels walking across the desert, giving that final touch of authenticity.

S A R A ' S B L O G



These figurines were done entirely by hand every fold, every detail, every expression. It took hours of concentration and a lot of patience. Choosing to avoid molds made the work at least three times harder, but it gave life and individuality to each character. They weren't perfect copies. They were unique, alive, and full of personality.

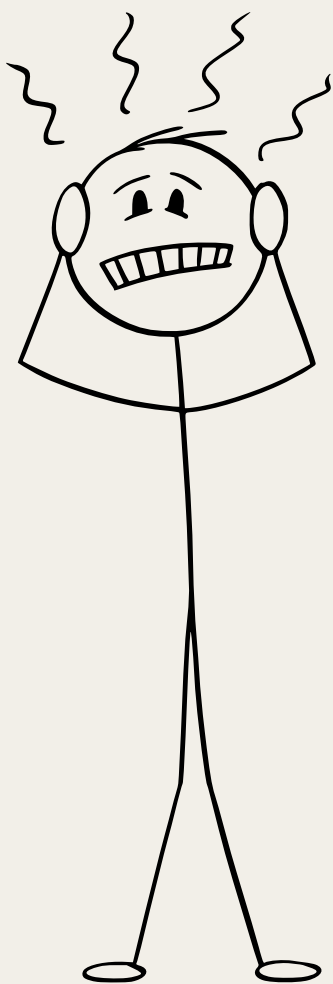
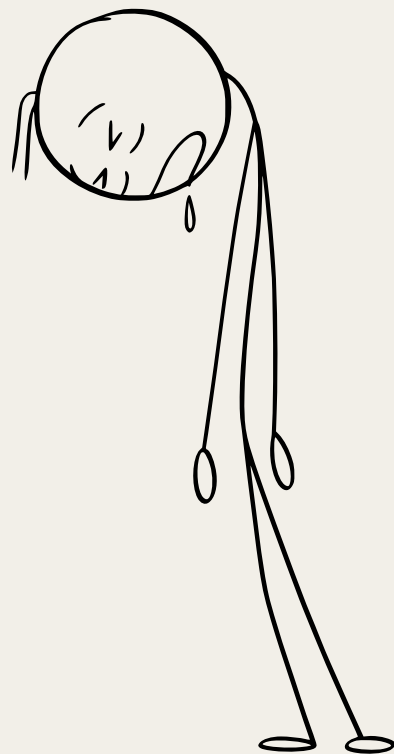


This decision cost us time and energy, but it also made the project truly ours. No silicone, no mold, no repetition just our hands, our culture, and our vision.

SARA’S BLOG

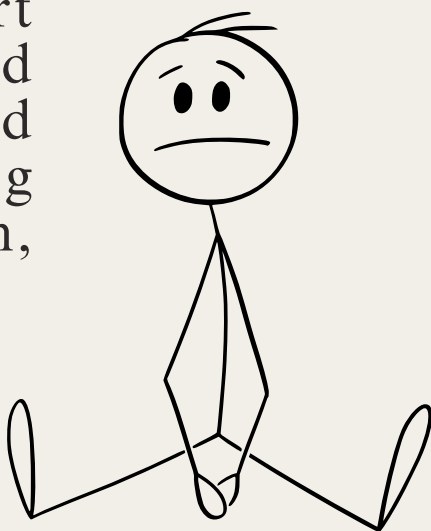
Weak moments...

The real problem was everything happening around us. We still had classes to teach, orders to finish, and responsibilities we couldn’t delay or cancel. That was the real stress. There were days when I felt I couldn’t do it anymore. My hands were shaking from exhaustion, and my body was literally giving up. My colleague kept telling me, “*Please finish what you started*,” but my energy was gone. Time was running so fast only one week left before traveling and the biggest parts were still not finished.



I kept joking with Chef Sara El Fetouh that we were going to arrive at the competition like **zombies**. And honestly, it wasn’t far from the truth. We had zero time to rest. Not even one minute. Between the competition preparation, our classes, our orders, the house responsibilities, and life in general... it felt like everything was happening at the same time. My son had exams, so I had to study with him at night. My younger son still needed breastfeeding. Imagine trying to focus on figurines and architecture while your baby still needs you every few hours. I was torn between work and motherhood, and both sides were pulling hard.

And as if the pressure wasn’t enough, strange things kept happening. I fell on the stairs three times. Three times. While working with the drill to make holes in the MDF for the structure, it slipped and fell straight on my head. I was dizzy for hours. My hands were shaking from exhaustion. My whole body was sending warning signals, but time wasn’t stopping for anyone. Inside me, there was this constant fear: *how am I going to travel and leave my baby behind?* The part that people don’t see is the emotional weight behind the work. It’s not just about sugar, chocolate, and decorations. It’s about sacrifices, about choosing between being a mother, a teacher, a businesswoman, and a competitor... all at once.

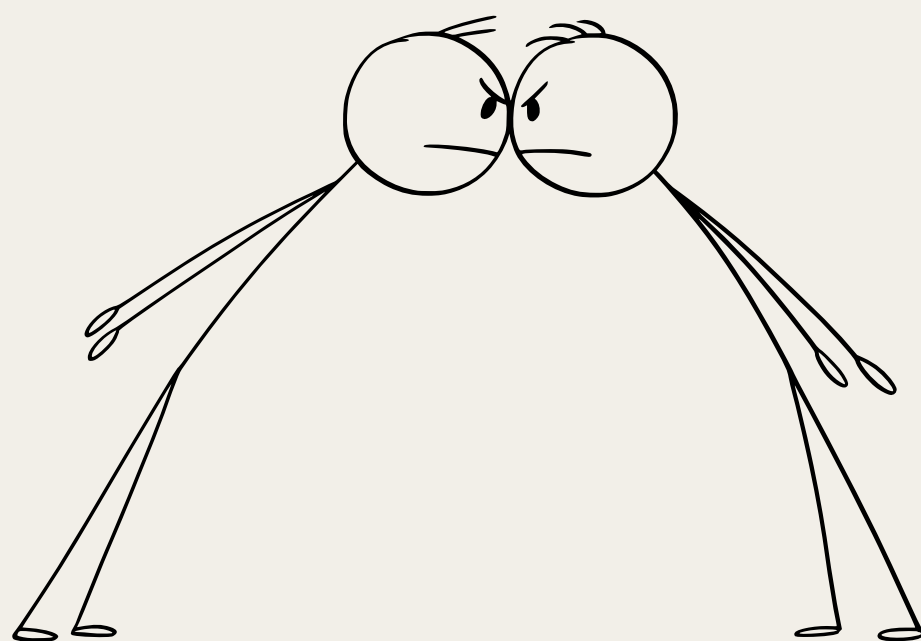


S A R A ' S B L O G

Those days felt endless. I was tired in a way I had never experienced before. But somehow, with every breakdown moment, something inside me kept saying: *“You’ve come this far. Keep going.”* And that’s exactly what I did.

There is something nobody tells you about big events: the weak moments don’t arrive politely. They crash into your life exactly when you think you’re finally safe.

During the final masterclass before Rome, we were finally happy relieved, even to close all classes and dedicate ourselves fully to training, until life intervened in the most brutal way. In the middle of our excitement, Sara received the call announcing her grandmother’s passing, and the atmosphere collapsed instantly. She was crying, and strangely, I felt even sadder than her, because I knew what such a loss does to a heart, and because her absence meant I would have to continue the masterclass alone, train alone, and carry both the emotional weight and the pressure of the competition by myself. That moment confused me deeply; I wasn’t ready for loneliness at a time when every detail mattered, and I felt torn between grief, guilt, and responsibility. Yet it’s funny how the weakest moments become part of the fire that pushes you forward later.



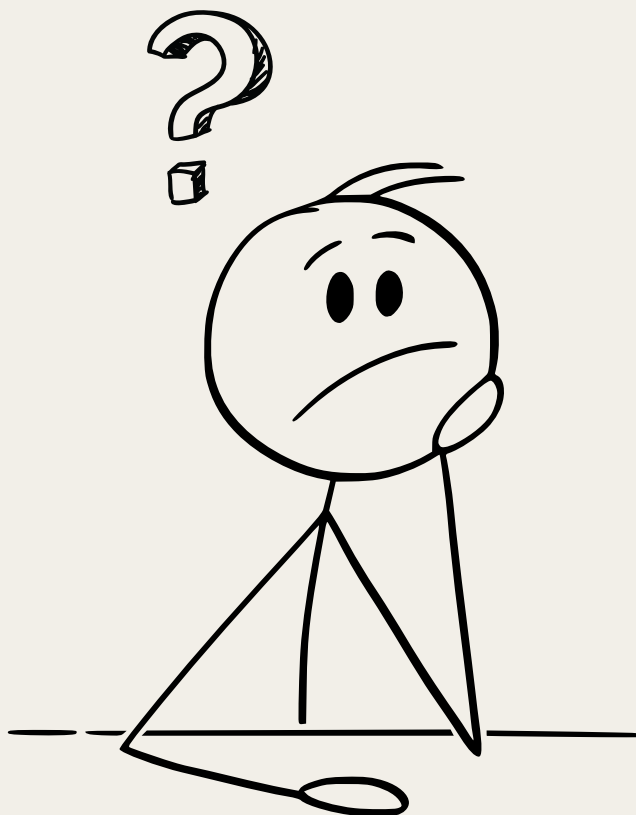
Fighting those weak moments felt like me against myself. And honestly, that is the hardest battle anyone can face. When the problem isn’t time, or tools, or pressure but your own body saying “stop” while your mind says “keep going.” At some point I told myself: *it’s now or never. Get up and find a way to finish what you started.*

I remember it clearly. It was a Saturday. No one was with me just me alone in the atelier. I closed the door, played some music, took a deep breath, and started working. Somehow, in one single day, I finished everything I was stuck on. I don’t even know how the energy came back, but it did. I kept sending pictures to Chef Sara El Fetouh while working, and she kept cheering me up through messages, making me laugh and pushing me to continue.

That moment showed me again that :

Sometimes the only person who can save you... is you.

S A R A ' S B L O G



Three days before leaving for Rome, Mr. Amine told me that a transport driver would come pick up our materials including the cake and take everything by truck, while we would travel by plane. I called the driver to double-check the schedule, and that's when I heard a surprise that almost made my heart stop.

He showed up with a small car.

A tiny one.

Big enough only for our team's boxes and the chocolate team. Nothing more.

I remember saying, **"What?!"**

I felt a wave of stress hit me. I told him to forget about me and that I would manage my own transport... but how? How were we going to take almost 150 kg of fragile materials on the plane? With delicate figurines, decorations, MDF pieces, tools... it was impossible.

That day I reached burnout. I was exhausted mentally and physically. I just prayed that God would send a solution, because I had nothing left to give.

The next morning, I got a phone call:

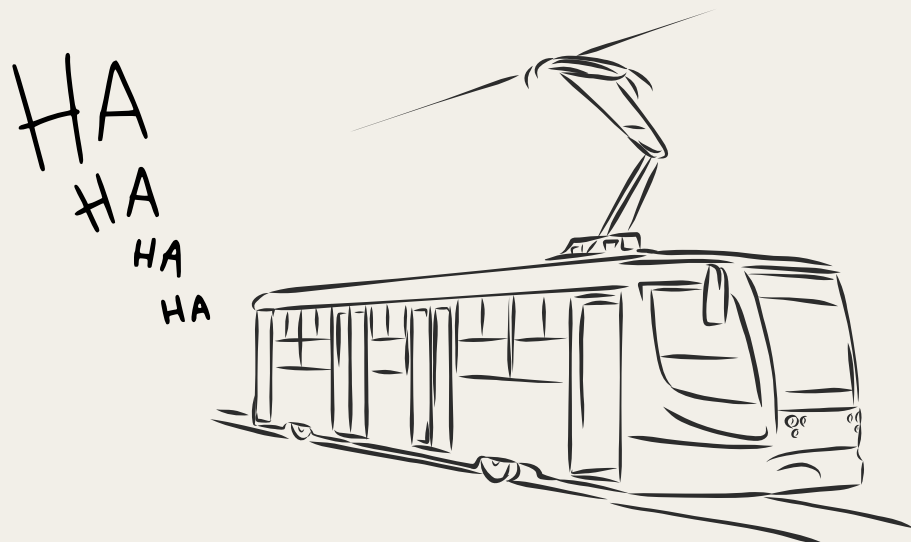
"Good news, there's still a bit of space left in the truck. He will come to you and load as much as he can. Whatever remains, we'll solve it or pay extra at the airport."

Before I could even think, my husband jumped in with his own plan using his "Tetris skills," as he calls them, to fit everything inside that tiny space. And somehow... he did it. He reorganized everything, pushed, stacked, rotated, recalculated. The transport guy was shocked. I was standing there laughing from stress and relief at the same time.

Thanks to him, almost everything made it into the truck.

And just like that, the road to Rome finally started to open.

S A R A ' S B L O G



But wait ! i was about to forget about the TGV adventure or how the chaos travels faster than us..

The day we had to go to Casablanca to the Italian consulate should have been simple.

Take the TGV. Meet Sara. Get the passport. Check the visa. Come back.

Simple.

Except nothing in our life ever chooses simple.

I arrived at the train station early and waited near one door. Sara arrived too... but at another door. Each of us was convinced the other hadn't arrived yet. I remember thinking, "Why not just wait inside the train?" which, in retrospect, was the exact moment chaos officially started.

While I was calmly waiting inside, Sara was outside... waiting for me. Messages were sent. The network decided to disappear exactly when communication was most needed. And then, suddenly, I saw her running toward the train, trying to catch it at the last second, looking extremely determined... and extremely mad at me.

We sat down, slightly stressed, slightly laughing... until I realized something much worse.

I had forgotten the most important paper required to collect the passport.

Silence.

Then chaos.

Calls to my husband. Rapid brainstorming. Mental calculations that made zero sense. Two men sitting in front of us had witnessed the entire drama like spectators in a live theatre show. They introduced themselves "engineers traveling for work" and immediately started suggesting solutions. Many ideas. Very creative ones. None of them actually possible.

In the end, we accepted the only realistic option: go anyway... and hope for a miracle.

When they asked why we were going to Rome, we explained the competition. Their reaction changed instantly. They became excited, supportive, proud, especially when they learned we were engineers too. Suddenly the journey felt lighter, like we were not just traveling, but carrying a story.

S A R A ’ S B L O G

And then... miracle.
At the consulate, everything went unexpectedly smooth. The missing paper? They skipped it. Sometimes life rewards courage... or maybe just chaos management skills.

But the real comedy started on the way back.

We took a taxi. The driver asked what we had been doing at the consulate. A normal question, until it became an interrogation.

“You got an Italian visa? For what?”
“For work.”
“What work?”
“Pastry.”



He stopped. Turned. And almost shouted:
“If you come back to Morocco after Italy, you are both stupid. Stay there. Never come back. You have no future here as pastry women.”

That moment stayed with me.
Because earlier that day, two engineers had encouraged us and celebrated our journey. Now another person saw the exact same reality through a completely different lens.

And suddenly I realized: this is not new.
When I first left engineering for pastry, reactions were the same. Some people saw madness. Others saw genius.

The truth is, your path will always look strange to someone especially when you choose passion over expectations. And maybe that’s part of the journey too.

S A R A ' S B L O G

The Juice Philosopher

On the way back in the TGV, I thought the chaos was finally over. I was wrong. I sat down facing a man while holding a juice. The moment I tried to settle into my seat, he looked at me very seriously and said:

“That juice is not good for you.”

I smiled politely.

“Yes, you’re right,” I answered, already thinking I might not even finish it.

But that simple comment opened a door. He started talking. And talking. And talking. Within minutes I knew his entire life story.

He had just come back from Germany to get an official paper that was supposed to help him skip a position and advance in his career. He didn’t get it. He spent a lot of money. Many attempts. No success. He wanted to get married. Never found the right person. He wanted to move forward. Something always blocked him. It felt like a long list of dreams that almost happened but never quite reached the finish line. Then, like everyone else that day, he asked:

“So what do you do?”

We explained our work, the competition, Rome, the project. His energy changed immediately. He became encouraging, supportive... but with one strong conclusion:

“You should go live in Germany!”

I couldn’t help laughing inside.

After listening to his stories of endless problems there, I finally answered:

“So you really want us to go through all the problems you just described? Maybe it’s you who needs to come to Morocco, get married, and relax a little.”

He laughed. Sara laughed. Even I laughed. And at that moment I realized something funny: During one single day, we met three types of people.

The engineers who saw opportunity.

The taxi driver who saw limitation.

And the philosopher of the train who saw escape.

Everyone gives advice based on the life they are living.

And maybe the real lesson is simple:

People don’t describe the world as it is. They describe it as they experience it.

S A R A ' S B L O G

And now it was time.

Time to leave Tangier, cross the country to Casablanca airport, and step into the chapter that had been haunting my dreams for months. My husband insisted on driving me himself. He wanted to wish me luck, to hold my hand one last time before Rome, to make sure I felt grounded before flying.

It sounds dramatic, but the truth is: it was our first time ever not traveling together.

That hit harder than I expected.

I'm used to having him beside me for every detail, tickets, luggage, problems, last-minute decisions, all the micro-chaos of any trip. Walking alone into an international competition without him felt like stepping into a world that didn't have my usual safety net. A small voice inside me kept whispering: "*What if something goes wrong in Rome and he's not there?*"

But then... I reached the airport, and suddenly the sadness softened.

The whole Moroccan team was there:

Mr. Amine,
Chef Sara El Fetouh,
Chef Simo El Amraoui,
Chef Ali Gousaid,
Chef Mohamed El Yazidi,
Chef Omar Eddib,
and the photography guy.

A small army, all carrying the same dream.

And then there was Simo El Amraoui, our accompagnant, our "guardian of logistics, coordination, managing" the man who somehow knew everything, remembered everything, and handled everything. We had been in contact nonstop for two months, planning, checking rules, preparing details. Somewhere during that chaos, we became real friends. Knowing he was with us made me feel safe.

We gathered, laughed, stressed, took photos, and tried (unsuccessfully) to hide how nervous we all were. I won't talk about the funny airport moments here, because Rome deserves its own comedy film but trust me, the trip had already started in the most Moroccan way possible 😊.

And then the moment came, Bording... ✈️

A mix of fear, excitement, pride... and that strange silence you feel inside right before a big storm of emotions.

We flew.

And we arrived safely in Rome tired, hopeful, and ready to write a new page of Morocco's pastry history.



S A R A ' S B L O G

To be continued ...



S A R A ' S B L O G

S A R A ' S B L O G